Don't used lettuces that have bolted for this—they will have bitter cores. Some of the leaves may still be good to use, though. Taste before using.

lettuce soup with peas

SERVES 4 **PREP** 30 MINS, PLUS 30 MINS CHILLING **FREEZE** NOT SUITABLE

CHILLED

4½oz (125g) peas (shelled weight)
1 small garlic clove
pinch of coarse salt
2 medium heads lettuce (about 1lb 2oz/ 500g in total), cleaned, torn into pieces, and solid cores discarded
1 cup plain yogurt
¾in (2cm) piece fresh ginger, peeled and finely grated
handful of mint leaves
juice of ½ lemon
salt and freshly ground black pepper

1 Bring a small amount of water to a boil in a pan, add the peas, and cook for 1 minute. Drain (reserving the cooking water), cool under cold running water, and refrigerate. Cut the garlic in half, remove any green at the center, and discard. Crush the halves along with a pinch of coarse salt.

2 Combine the garlic with all the other ingredients (except the peas) in a food processor or blender, adding just enough of the reserved cooking water to get the blades moving or until the desired consistency is achieved—this will vary according to the type of lettuce and the kind of machine you are using, but it is nice if you can get it fairly smooth, with a bit of texture.

3 Transfer the soup to a large bowl and chill for 30 minutes. When ready to serve, stir through the cooked peas, leaving a few to garnish.

CHOOSING AND PREPARING LETTUCE
Search your farmers' market for lettuces with fresh-looking leaves and a silky, slightly firm heart. Avoid any that are wilted or bruised. To clean, pat the leaves with damp paper towels, then tear them—rather than cut—to size.

